

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 804

By Faison

A RESOLUTION urging the Secretary of State to include *The Old Men: The conversations that help boys become men* by T.L. Jones in the *Tennessee Blue Book*.

WHEREAS, one of the foundational principles of the Appalachian people is a fierce respect for their elders, who are the patriarchs and matriarchs of their families and whose words carry the weight of generations; and

WHEREAS, the importance of sharing and receiving generational wisdom remains paramount to the people of Appalachia today; and

WHEREAS, sadly, the longstanding ways of Appalachia are quickly fading in these contemporary times; however, an insider's view of traditional Appalachian culture and values can be gleaned from *The Old Men: The conversations that help boys become men* by T.L. Jones (2024); and

WHEREAS, *The Old Men* transports the reader into the early life of an Appalachian boy, born in 1970, who was influenced by the thinking and the words of the old men of Appalachia and a few others, as he later wandered outside "the land of the blue smoke"; and

WHEREAS, the eighty-four essays contained in this book, as its title suggests, represent the conversations that help boys become men; although the book is firmly rooted in Appalachia, the principle of passing wisdom from old men to boys is universal and timeless; and

WHEREAS, in *The Old Men*, Mr. Jones relates many exciting adventures and provides keen insight into the mountain wisdom that he learned at the knees of his elders, including essays about Faith in God, Equipment Maintenance, Bar Fights, Murder, Church, Respecting Elders, Bear Hunting, Trout Fishing, Poverty, Hard Work, Grace, and Salvation; and

WHEREAS, a native son of East Tennessee, T.L. Jones spent much of his boyhood in the company of old men, farming, hunting, fishing, and "loafing" with them in the mountains of Appalachia; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Jones became a Christian at the age of eighteen and was called to the ministry in 1990; while spreading the good news of the Gospel, he planted and pastored two churches, one in Whitehall, Montana, and the other in Greeneville; and

WHEREAS, T.L. Jones has expertly crafted a work that brings to the life the everyday experiences, unique culture, and time-honored values of the people of Appalachia, the high esteem in which they hold their elders, and the great importance they place upon generational wisdom; and

WHEREAS, the Secretary of State publishes the *Tennessee Blue Book* biennially for the edification and enjoyment of all Tennesseans; Section VI, which focuses on the State of Tennessee's history and heritage, includes a chapter on "State Arts and Crafts"; and

WHEREAS, given the book's cultural and historical significance and its impact on the lives of so many Tennesseans, it is fitting that the Secretary of State should recognize *The Old Men* in the *Tennessee Blue Book*; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we hereby urge the Secretary of State to include reference to *The Old Men: The conversations that help boys become men* by T.L. Jones in the *Tennessee Blue Book*, along with an appropriate explanation of the book's subject matter and its significance in illustrating and illuminating the history and culture of Appalachia.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an enrolled copy of this resolution be transmitted to the Secretary of State.